

Why spend a week or more on retreat?

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Tips of the Day · 3 min read

Bhante Bodhidhamma Each year I run a Practice in Ordinary Daily Life Course: PODL. Every month over the winter, January to March, there is a day retreat at the beginning of the month and a meeting at the end where everyone shares their experience. As you would expect, the aim of moment to moment mindfulness is enhanced and there is a general feeling of good work done. And with that encouragement comes the desire to continue to bring the practice into every sphere of our lives. But note, it begins with a day devoted to sitting and walking meditation. In other words, a special effort to lift that energy for spiritual purposes. And that ultimate purpose is Nibbāna which unfortunately sounds as nebulous as Shangri-La. But grounding Nibbāna in everyday experience simply means there is less and less suffering from habitual reactivity driven by our demons – acquisitiveness, aversion, fear, guilt, shame and so on and so on. In other words, it is all about Dukkha, undermining our tendency to create suffering and unsatisfactoriness for ourselves. And this takes effort! And that is the role of at least a week of meditation practice every year. And the more the better. So the first reason to come on a retreat, is to lift the enthusiasm needed to continue our practice in daily life. But, of course, that energy is supporting other crucial aims during the week. The first is to stop! Calm down. Let go of the stress and excitements of life. Bring ourselves into a state of the ‘effortless effort’. The ability to observe, feel and investigate our body, hearts and minds without some idea of achieving anything. For when we have an idea of what we want to achieve that becomes the goal and distorts the ability ‘to see and understand how things come to be right now’. That is why our awareness, Sati, is choiceless and it is in this state that the intuitive intelligence, Panya, which is but the active part of Sati, can have insights no matter how small into our habits and behaviour, some that cause us harm and others that enhance our lives. As the effort to just watch and feel settles, there grows that one-pointedness of attention and we begin to see more clearly the Three Characteristics of Existence: how mistaken desire is a direct cause of our feeling of never being fully satisfied; how we do not allow ourselves to experience impermanence by always living into the next moment and dodging the collapse of the last moment; and how this illusion a self, of me and of what I own as mine, is creating fear and anxiety and a host of secondary sufferings. For it is this very self that needs to shore itself up with acquiring wealth, friends, power and so on. Then it has to protect its possessions from others either by angry, hateful tactics or hiding and avoiding. Such insights feed into our attitudes and the unwholesome ones are undermined and the positive ones enhanced. All the guides for a Camino or pilgrimage tell you to prepare physically by doing lots of walking before you even start. You need to have some physical fitness. A pilgrimage is a metaphor for the spiritual life. The pilgrim has to gather their energy and be prepared to undergo discomfort to reach the goal which for them signifies some spiritual realisation. For the practitioner, the practice and the goal are one and the same thing. Every moment of

every day is practice and every moment of every day is a piece of the goal. The goal is here and now! Nibbana is staring us in the face, but we cannot see it save in little aha moments. But that constant gentle effort brings its own rewards – less greed, less anger, less anxiety. If we do not put that extra effort into our practice, laziness sets in and the practice wanes. Old habits we have worked to undermine regain their strength. And it all begins to feel hopeless. That is when the alarm bell rings. And there is no better way to regain the enthusiasm than to devote a specific length of time to the meditation. The Buddha never said it was easy! Spiritual practice goes against the stream. But talked about the end of the journey being fulfilment, contentment and the highest joy. The Buddha's own caring encouragement to Ananda, his companion for 20 years: Whatever a teacher should do who cares for the welfare of his disciples, I have done for you, Ananda. There are the roots of trees and empty huts. Do not delay, Ananda. Meditate now lest you regret it later. This is my encouragement to you. (MN152.18) Let's take that to heart! Let's do a little extra this year!

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